

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 1

New Case: Aryan (32 y/o, Software Engineer, Kochi)

Full Detailed – More Realistic Style

SESSION INFORMATION

Client: Aryan (32 years, Male)

Therapist: Dr. A.

Session #: 1 of 18–20 planned

Presenting Issue: Moderate-Severe GAD + Burnout

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

New client. 32-year-old software engineer working in a product company in Kochi. Presenting with 9–10 months of increasing anxiety related to work performance, fear of making mistakes, sleep disturbance, and signs of burnout. He continues to deliver good work but at high personal cost. Self-referred after a panic-like episode before an important meeting. BDI-II = 21, GAD-7 = 17. No previous therapy. Risk appears low. Plan: Build rapport, understand presenting problems, introduce CBT model gently, set initial goals, and assign simple monitoring homework.

SESSION START – BUILDING RAPPORT

Therapist: Good morning, Aryan. Thank you for coming in today. I know starting therapy can feel like a big step, so I appreciate you being here. How are you feeling about this first session?

Client: A bit nervous actually. I've never done this before. I'm not even sure if therapy is going to help me or not.

Therapist: That's completely normal. Many people feel nervous or unsure in the beginning. It's okay to have doubts. Today we'll just focus on understanding what's been going on for you and see if this approach makes sense. There's no pressure. Everything we talk about stays confidential.

Client: Okay... thanks for saying that.

PRESENTING PROBLEMS

Aryan described experiencing excessive worry about his work performance for the past 9–10 months. He constantly fears making mistakes in code or during meetings, and worries that others will think he is not competent. This worry has become almost constant, especially in the evenings and before important meetings or code reviews.

He experiences physical symptoms such as racing heart, sweating, muscle tension, and occasional panic-like episodes (difficulty breathing, fear of losing control) before presentations or meetings with senior colleagues.

Sleep has been disturbed — he finds it hard to fall asleep because his mind keeps replaying work situations, and he often wakes up early with worry. He feels constantly tired and emotionally drained.

He has become more irritable with his wife and colleagues. He has started avoiding casual interactions in the office and often stays back late to double-check his work, even when it's not necessary.

BRIEF HISTORY

Symptoms gradually increased over the last 9–10 months, coinciding with higher project pressure and a new, more demanding team lead. He had one previous period of high stress during his first job (around age 26), which improved when the project ended. No history of trauma or substance use. He describes himself as someone who has always been a high achiever and tends to put a lot of pressure on himself to perform well.

INTRODUCTION TO CBT MODEL

Therapist: From what you've shared, it sounds like your worry and anxiety have become quite strong and are affecting both your work and personal life. One way we look at this in CBT is by understanding the connection between our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. Would it be okay if I show you with one of your recent experiences?

Client: Okay...

Therapist: Can you tell me about a recent situation where your anxiety was quite high?

Client: Last week I had to present some new features to my team lead and two seniors. I spent almost three days preparing and re-checking everything. The night before, I barely slept.

Therapist: And during that time, what kind of thoughts were going through your mind?

Client: I kept thinking that if I miss even one small thing or explain something wrong, they'll think I don't know what I'm doing. They'll start doubting me.

Therapist: And when you had those thoughts, how did you feel emotionally and physically? What did you end up doing?

Client: I felt very anxious and ashamed. My heart was racing and my hands were sweating. I ended up staying up until 2 AM checking everything again and again.

Therapist: So we can see how those thoughts led to very strong anxiety, which then led to staying up very late — and the next day you probably felt even more tired and anxious. This is the kind of cycle we often work on in CBT. Does this way of looking at it make sense to you?

Client: Yeah... I can see it. I never really thought about it like this before.

COLLABORATIVE GOAL SETTING

Therapist: If therapy is helpful, what would you like to be different in the next few months?

Client: I want to stop feeling so scared before every meeting. I want to sleep properly. I want to feel like I can make small mistakes without it ruining my whole week. And I want to be less irritable with my wife.

Therapist: Those are very clear goals. We can work on making them more specific as we go forward. For now, this gives us a good direction.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this first week, I'd like you to start a simple daily diary. It only takes a few minutes each time. Just note:

1. Time of day and a brief situation
2. Your mood rating from 0 to 10
3. What you were doing
4. Any strong thoughts that came up

This will help us understand the patterns more clearly. Do you think you can try this for the next week?

Client: I can try... but I'm not sure if I'll remember to do it every day.

Therapist: That's completely fine. Just do it whenever you can. Even 4–5 entries will be helpful. We'll review it next session.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we talked about what's been going on for you, looked at how thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are connected, and set some initial goals. We also agreed on the first homework. How are you feeling about today's session?

Client: It was okay. I still don't know if this will really help, but I'm willing to try.

Therapist: That's fair. We'll take it step by step. Any questions before we finish?

Client: Not really.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client presented with clear symptoms of moderate-severe GAD with burnout features.
- Some initial skepticism about therapy was expressed (realistic).
- Client was able to identify thoughts-feelings-behaviors connection with gentle guidance.
- Homework was agreed upon with some expressed doubt about consistency (realistic).
- Risk: Low. Next session: Review homework diary, deepen formulation, identify key negative automatic thoughts.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.